Active and passive voice

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1. Topic Overview and Learning Objectives

Active and passive voice is a fundamental pillar of English grammar that dictates how we express the relationship between the subject and the action in a sentence. In the active voice, the subject performs the action, making the sentence direct and energetic. Conversely, the passive voice shifts the focus to the receiver of the action, often placing the subject at the end or omitting it entirely. Understanding this distinction is vital for clear communication and effective writing.

For your Class 9 Federal Board examinations, this topic carries significant weight in the grammar section. Examiners frequently test your ability to convert sentences across various tenses, including simple, continuous, and perfect forms. Mastering these transformations not only helps you secure full marks in the objective and subjective parts of the paper but also improves your essay and letter writing skills by allowing you to vary your sentence structure for better flow.

The intuition behind passive voice is simple: it is used when the action itself is more important than the person or thing performing it, or when the doer is unknown. By learning the systematic rules for changing the object into the subject and adjusting the verb form, you gain control over your writing style. This guide breaks down these rules into manageable sections, ensuring you are fully prepared for any question that appears on your board paper.

2. Core Concepts and Detailed Revision Notes

2.1 Fundamentals of Voice Conversion

To successfully convert a sentence from active to passive voice, you must first identify the three main components: the subject, the verb, and the object. The subject is the doer, the verb is the action, and the object is the receiver. The golden rule of conversion is to swap the positions of the subject and the object. Once swapped, the object becomes the new subject of the passive sentence. You must then change the main verb into its third form, which is the past participle. Furthermore, the word 'by' is usually added before the original subject, which now acts as the agent. Always remember that the tense of the sentence must be maintained throughout this process. If the active sentence is in the present tense, the passive sentence must also reflect the present tense through the appropriate auxiliary verb.

Key Points to Remember:

1. The object of the active sentence becomes the subject of the passive sentence.
2. The main verb is always changed to its third form (past participle).
3. The preposition 'by' is used to introduce the agent of the action.
4. The tense of the sentence must remain consistent during conversion.
5. Pronouns must be changed to their objective case when they move to the end.

2.2 Tense-Based Transformations

The most critical aspect of voice conversion is adjusting the auxiliary verbs based on the tense of the original sentence. For simple present tense, we use 'is', 'am', or 'are' followed by the past participle. In simple past tense, we use 'was' or 'were'. For continuous tenses, we introduce the word 'being' after the auxiliary verb to indicate the ongoing nature of the action. Perfect tenses are unique because they already contain a past participle; therefore, we simply insert the word 'been' after the auxiliary verb 'has', 'have', or 'had'. It is essential to memorize these auxiliary patterns because they are the most common source of errors in board exams. Practice identifying the tense of the given sentence immediately so you know exactly which auxiliary verb to apply to your passive construction.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Simple Present: Use is/am/are + past participle.
2. Simple Past: Use was/were + past participle.
3. Continuous Tenses: Add 'being' after the auxiliary verb.
4. Perfect Tenses: Add 'been' after the auxiliary verb.
5. Future Tense: Use 'will be' or 'shall be' + past participle.

2.3 Handling Pronouns and Modals

When a pronoun acts as the subject in an active sentence, it must change its form when it moves to the object position in a passive sentence. For example, 'I' becomes 'me', 'he' becomes 'him', 'she' becomes 'her', 'we' becomes 'us', and 'they' becomes 'them'. This is known as the objective case. Additionally, when dealing with modal verbs such as 'can', 'could', 'should', 'must', or 'might', the conversion process is quite straightforward. You do not need to change the modal verb itself; instead, you simply add 'be' after the modal and then use the past participle of the main verb. For instance, 'He can do it' becomes 'It can be done by him'. Keeping these pronoun and modal rules in mind will ensure your sentences remain grammatically correct and formal.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Change 'I' to 'me' and 'He' to 'him' in the passive structure.
2. Change 'She' to 'her' and 'They' to 'them' in the passive structure.

3. Modal verbs are followed by 'be' in the passive voice.
4. The main verb always remains in the third form after a modal.
5. Do not change the modal verb's tense or form during conversion.

2.4 Negative and Interrogative Sentences

Negative and interrogative sentences require special attention during voice conversion. For negative sentences, keep the word 'not' in the same relative position as it was in the active sentence, ensuring it sits between the auxiliary verb and the past participle. For interrogative sentences, the structure must remain a question. If the sentence starts with 'Do' or 'Does', the passive version should start with 'Is', 'Am', or 'Are'. If it starts with 'Did', the passive version should start with 'Was' or 'Were'. If the sentence begins with 'Wh-' words like 'Who', 'What', or 'Where', the 'Wh-' word usually stays at the beginning, but 'Who' must be changed to 'By whom'. These structures can be tricky, so practice is the best way to ensure you do not lose marks on these specific types of questions.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Keep 'not' between the auxiliary verb and the past participle.
2. Start passive questions with the appropriate auxiliary verb.
3. Change 'Who' to 'By whom' at the start of the sentence.
4. Ensure the question mark is included at the end of the sentence.
5. Maintain the original meaning of the question during transformation.

3. Key Definitions, Formulas, and Rules

1. **Subject-Object Swap:** Active Subject becomes Passive Object; Active Object becomes Passive Subject.
2. **Verb Rule:** Always use the third form of the verb (past participle) in passive voice.
3. **Present Simple Passive:** Object + is/am/are + V3 + by + Subject.
4. **Past Simple Passive:** Object + was/were + V3 + by + Subject.
5. **Continuous Passive:** Object + aux verb + being + V3 + by + Subject.
6. **Perfect Passive:** Object + has/have/had + been + V3 + by + Subject.
7. **Modal Passive:** Object + modal + be + V3 + by + Subject.
8. **Pronoun Change:** I to me, we to us, he to him, she to her, they to them.
9. **Who Rule:** Who changes to By whom at the start of the passive sentence.

4. Step-by-Step Worked Examples

Example 1: Simple Present Conversion

Problem: She writes a letter.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify components: Subject (She), Verb (writes), Object (a letter).

Step 2: Move object to front: A letter.

Step 3: Choose auxiliary: 'is' (because 'a letter' is singular).

Step 4: Change verb to V3: written.

Step 5: Add 'by' and change subject: by her.

Final Answer: A letter is written by her.

Example 2: Past Continuous Conversion

Problem: They were playing cricket.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify components: Subject (They), Verb (were playing), Object (cricket).

Step 2: Move object to front: Cricket.

Step 3: Choose auxiliary: 'was' (because 'cricket' is singular).

Step 4: Add 'being' for continuous: was being.

Step 5: Change verb to V3: played.

Step 6: Add 'by' and change subject: by them.

Final Answer: Cricket was being played by them.

Example 3: Modal Verb Conversion

Problem: You must finish the work.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify components: Subject (You), Verb (must finish), Object (the work).

Step 2: Move object to front: The work.

Step 3: Keep modal and add 'be': must be.

Step 4: Change verb to V3: finished.

Step 5: Add 'by' and change subject: by you.

Final Answer: The work must be finished by you.

Example 4: Interrogative Conversion

Problem: Did he buy a book?

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify components: Subject (he), Verb (did buy), Object (a book).

Step 2: Start with auxiliary: Was (because 'a book' is singular).

Step 3: Move object to front: a book.

Step 4: Change verb to V3: bought.

Step 5: Add 'by' and change subject: by him.

Step 6: Add question mark.

Final Answer: Was a book bought by him?

5. Common Exam Mistakes to Avoid

1. Forgetting to change the verb to the third form (past participle). Always check your verb form.
2. Incorrectly using auxiliary verbs. Ensure the auxiliary matches the new subject, not the old one.
3. Omitting the 'by' agent when it is necessary for the meaning of the sentence.
4. Failing to change pronouns like 'I' to 'me' or 'he' to 'him' when moving them to the end.
5. Changing the tense of the sentence. Remember, the tense must remain the same in both voices.
6. Forgetting to add 'being' or 'been' in continuous or perfect tenses, which is a very common error.

6. Practice Questions and Model Answers

Question 1

Change into passive: The gardener waters the plants.

Answer 1: The plants are watered by the gardener.

Question 2

Change into passive: He has finished his homework.

Answer 2: His homework has been finished by him.

Question 3

Change into passive: Who broke the window?

Answer 3: By whom was the window broken?

Question 4

Change into passive: They will not accept the offer.

Answer 4: The offer will not be accepted by them.

Question 5

Change into passive: She was singing a song.

Answer 5: A song was being sung by her.